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More Human Than Human

In 1982, director Ridley Scott gave us *Blade Runner* – a science fiction neo-noir about Rick Deckard, a dystopian-era android mercenary, who embarks on a hunt to “retire” advanced artificial life forms who have escaped their off-world slave-labor prison and are grappling with angry, violent emotions toward their creators as they struggle to survive. Scott and his team employed all elements of mise-en-scene, music, and cinematography to create a film that aesthetically buffers the narrative’s key themes, which include man’s relationship with his environment as a consequence of consumerism and technology and raises the question of what constitutes humanity – is it merely our genetic birthright or a product of our emotions and desires? In the film, the physical setting is very much both a cause and effect of these character’s internal and external conflict. The music enhances our sense of place and time, and repeated themes underscore these internal conflicts. Various elements of mise-en-scene and cinematography establish a massive, industrial dystopia that also lends itself to a sense of place, time, and emotional atmosphere, planting us firmly in some distant (but maybe not so distant) future, where androids blend seamlessly into a human crowd, and technological industry is god.

While it is quite tempting to explicate every scene of this film, the opening credits and a scene in which Deckard chases down and retires an escaped replicant, Zhora, serve as adequate bites that we might consume to know the taste of the full film’s aesthetic approach to defining and elaborating upon its narrative. The elements specifically explored in these scenes include

lighting, performance and action, costuming and makeup, composition and framing, with emphasis primarily on set design and physical setting, and style elements of music, and cinematography.

The opening sequence begins with names of our key players and director appearing on a black background; our film title appears in bold red upon a black background, and the music wastes no time in emphatically supporting the visual elements. The score initially begins as a deep, yet hollow, atonal synthesizer drum that punctuates some of the names on screen, with the most emphasis on our film title; the title is also the job title of our protagonist, and the emphatic drum suggests that this story belongs to this character and this job is the crux of our main character's conflict. As the credits progress, the atonal drum-like sounds are interspersed with soft, slightly melodic but dissonant, high-pitched synthesizer music. The synthetic musical notes underscore the futuristic element, but the atonal arrhythmic jazz-like melody recalls the haunting yet romantic jazzy scores of film noir. The credits then open up to a text crawl that offers some backstory about our replicants; the synthesizer hums relentlessly, with one last industrial drum-like emphatic note when we are presented with the date this story takes place, and then transitions almost seamlessly to a wide shot of our cityscape, the jazzy ebb and flow of our synthesizer punctuated by machinery and industrial foley and sound effects, a blend of diegetic sound - rhythmic blasting of fiery plumes from a sea of endless industrial smokestacks and unnatural whizzing of vehicles through the air - and nondiegetic sound – a jazzy, futuristic synthesizer score - that merge harmoniously to create an atmosphere that is somehow futuristic, darkly commodified, nostalgic, and mysterious in its references.

Other meaningful elements of the opening sequence include lighting, physical setting, cinematography, and performance (or lack thereof). The darkness of our credits and text crawl transform into an aerial perspective of a bleak dark cityscape; our extreme wide shot of “where” is bathed in haze and darkness, and the only real sources of light are artificial or a byproduct of commercial interests, not the sun or the stars. The sky is drab brown and dark, and below it is a vast, dark cityscape peppered with tiny orange and teal building lights, as though the stars in the sky fell to earth and stayed there. The underexposure and heightened contrast between the lighting and flat darkness of everything else impart a bleakness and uniformity on this world and create an indiscernible soup of dark masses and tiny lights. As the camera descends very slowly toward this mass, some of the forms – predominantly the recognizably industrial ones – become more defined by their proximal sources of illumination, emphasizing the values of this particular society. The sprinkle of lights and eruptions of factory fire reflect diffusely across an atmospheric smog-like haze in the sky; it feels dangerous and inhospitable for nature and life. Our only indication of possible life is the smattering of lights and the occasional flying vehicle. One flying vehicle zooms toward the viewer and a plume of fire fills the frame with threatening proximity, giving depth cues to indicate the scope and dimension of this industrial cityscape, and drawing attention to what is behind them – two geometric shapes taking form as architecture. The scene then cuts to an extreme close up of a human eye reflecting the same glittering sea of industry, then back to the two geometric shapes – evidently, we are traveling along as this unknown character and seeing their world as they see it. Now the previously distant geometry takes form as two massive glittering pyramids framed by a wall of tall industrial towers jutting into the atmosphere. The shapes of the visually

defined structures offer verisimilitude by way of familiar callbacks to oil refinery flares and the pyramids of Egypt; Tyrell Corporation is located in these pyramids (interestingly also Tyrell's eventual tomb), sending the biggest and brightest lights of this entire cityscape upward into the sky. The framing and composition reveal very few other flying cars in the sky, validating that this narrative does occur in the future despite its familiar elements, but the number of them – there are very few relative to the lights below – suggest that, despite what looks like a humongous society, very few can afford the luxury of such advanced technology. This wide shot of the city abruptly cuts to a much closer shot of the pyramids, with one centered in frame, consuming the bulk of the space, at an angle looming above the camera, designating its importance both as the destination for our unknown flying vehicle POV and its potential influence. The other is barely visible behind its counterpart; the lighting is more low-key, contrast is more defined, and this shape not only has form, but now it has texture – there are also more flying vehicles in the airspace surrounding this corporate monolith. The scope, contrast, shift of camera angle downward, and reframing reinforces their importance to this narrative or to this world; Tyrell Corporation is perhaps the body politic and social ideology, the economic locus of this dystopia, worthy of such a massive structure, powerful enough to light the sky. Once more it cuts to an extreme close up of a human eye overlaid with a reflection of city lights – these eye reflections are the extent of performance in the opening sequence, and it underscores the power of this environment on this unknown character's experience and possibly on the other characters as well. Finally, the opening sequence reaches conclusion; camera movement picks up speed considerably as the audience is brought closer to the pyramidal structure, now revealing the extent of its futuristic texture, which resembles a

circuit board with its winding lines and visual points of light. This is undoubtedly the future, although stripped of life and nature, and rebuilt as a utilitarian shrine to commodification and manufacturing.

While the opening sequence provides a macro view of this dystopia and sets the circumstances allowing for our characters sense of lack or conflict, the other scene explored here offers a micro view at character-level. Deckard is tasked with retiring four escaped replicants; like all good noir detectives, he independently investigates a small lead and discovers the potential location of one of them – Taffey Lewis’ bar in Chinatown. Zhora is masquerading as a burlesque dancer there, and Deckard awkwardly attempts to investigate her after a performance, resulting in a chase scene at street-level. The chase scene establishes the atmosphere of this world underneath the veil of industry and tech and hint at Deckard’s increasing existentialist burden (as well as the one offered forth to the audience as we begin to see replicants as “more human than human”) as he struggles to reconcile his experience with Rachel, a newer replicant and object of his affection, with his sense of morality and duty as a blade runner.

As Deckard exits the bar in pursuit of Zhora, the lighting is low-key and dark, with bright neon signs and trash fires creating our only illumination in the rainy, foggy darkness. The sequence is mostly underexposed until the end, at which time Zhora exits the shadows and is exposed. As she is shot, she is fully illuminated by store lighting, and the entire death scene remains fully lit so we can see evidence of her humanness and Deckard’s reaction. Various red neons and bright store lights reflect off the glass as she falls through the storefronts, and it gives this dizzying, disorienting brightness a level of spectacle that underscores the drama of

her death, particularly as the red lights enhance the red streaks of blood down her body.

Throughout the sequence in general, the neon is quite pervasive in store signs, street signs, and crosswalk signals – all elements of a busy, capitalist urban center. The lighting is sourced from the environment; there are no natural or offscreen sources of illumination, the light colors are unnatural neon yellows, pinks, and reds and hyper saturated in contrast to the blur of dark blue, green, and violet shadows (giving this a cold emotional atmosphere with the mere illusion of warmth), and it is cast from the sides of characters, disorienting reflections in rainy street puddles, and from commercial signs barely above street level. No sunlight shines down from above here; street-level is gloomy and dark, and this society seems to favor commodity above all else. The physical setting and costuming further enhance this futuristic urban dystopia.

There is less evidence of residential building and a seemingly endless sea of commerce, vendors, stores, and markets. Traffic clogs the streets, which are quite close to buildings; the claustrophobia of the elements in the set give a sense of population density. In the beginning of the scene, we see street fires reminiscent of trash can fires created by people living rough in urban centers. It has a seediness and desperation to it that allow for this chase scene to take place without interruption or concern from bystanders. There are diverse crowds of people and various traffic elements surrounding the action as they take chase and it creates a visual labyrinth in which a replicant could easily disappear – if they actually wanted to disappear. The majority of the crowd is dressed in an interesting hybrid of 1940's noir elements, 1980's new wave influence, several references to traditional Asian fashions, religious fashions, and what could be considered “futuristic fashion” by virtue of the materials and accessories used (plastics, sunglasses in the darkness) diversity of cultures, different levels of modesty, and eras

and professions represented. Deckard has a trench coat; he is our noir protagonist, after all. Given the incredibly diverse fashion, it seems that anyone could blend into this version of the future, regardless of who (or what) they are. Zhora wears clear plastic over what amounts to underwear; she is literally and figuratively exposed now that Deckard has tracked her down.

As their chase ends, the physical setting is one of blatant consumerism – she breaks through multiple glass panels of what seems to be storefronts in a mini-mall – and the mannequins surrounding her offer an interesting visual juxtaposition of her human-like vulnerability to her purpose, which is to exist solely as a tool of consumerism. The actors' movements in this sequence and their interaction with this environment further support this perception. The acting itself is realistic – Deckard and Zhora are running, full speed as one would expect in a chase that will undoubtedly end in an execution if Zhora is captured, but the strangers around them, the general crowd, are primarily going about their business with no real interaction or interest. They seem almost desensitized to the panic and violence, not particularly reactive, possibly presuming that the individual being chased is “bad” and deserves it without question or empathy – they are just an extension of this dark, cold, uncaring environment, maybe less human than human. One woman in a vehicle gives Deckard a blank look as he appears panicked and dazed running through traffic; he breaks through a religious procession that continues onward despite the interruption. As the sequence comes to an end, Zhora's final moments as she is shot upend the expectation that replicants are bastions of physical strength and prowess. She grimaces dramatically in pain, moves clumsily, breaks through the glass wildly, emphatically without grace, almost as though she is breaking through the illusion of being just a tool of industry and coming out the other side as a bleeding,

vulnerable, fragile, imperfect life form. This vulnerability and fragility in her final moments is very explicitly human. Deckard's response is quiet observation as he moves closer, seemingly making a connection between what he is seeing, what he has experienced with Rachel, and a general unease with his "mission", since this scene in general seems to suggest that the real humans are not exactly kind or caring and the replicants (particularly the following scene when Rachel helps Deckard) might not warrant such abrupt execution.

Initially, the framing of this sequence is quite chaotic and dynamic, and due to the rapid pace, dark lighting, and fog, it's difficult to make out any details beyond the two characters running; mobile framing and seemingly hand-held camera movement during the chase gives a sense of POV of each character, capturing Deckard and Zhora's dynamic energy and maintaining a closeness of shot that enhances the claustrophobia of chasing someone through a crowd. The camera angles stay relatively level to the characters until the chase ends; it is above Zhora as she attempts to blend into a crowd, and below Deckard, suggesting that he has gained an advantage and now has control over the situation. The camera movement stabilizes and the framing of Zhora as she is executed shows her centrally, first as a close-medium shot as we see her expression upon being shot the first time, then as a long shot, and the frame rate slows considerably. It places an emphasis on taking in her death fully and reckoning with her illuminated vulnerability. As she falls forward, in shallow focus, it has an almost-dream-like quality, very unlike the initial panic of the chase. The framing of Deckard as he observes her death is also less close – a medium shot of him, veiled by artificial snow. The use of artificial snow here as Deckard approaches Zhora's dead body also provides an interesting device to suggest that his visibility is obscured, literally and figuratively; as he moves through the

storefront, and ultimately through the wall of fake snow, at which time he sees her very clearly – she is dead, but it’s an empty victory. There is a close shot of her face, bloodied and wide-eyed, and another shot of Deckard from somewhat level but slightly below – the power dynamic has been restored but at what cost to Deckard. Immediately after that, it cuts to a wide shot of city activity, as though once again, this is just another day in Chinatown - just a normal day in this future dystopia.

Interestingly, this scene relies less on music, and its use of diegetic sound along with mobile framing gives a very real sense of being there, running with Deckard and Zhora, and feeling the same escalating wave of panic and anticipation as we near climax. Most of the soundtrack here relies on traffic sounds – crosswalk alerts, horns, and the general hustle and bustle of urbanity – to enhance the set design and give it a verisimilitude of place and culture while also giving it a dizzying and disorienting quality. However, we get a return to our jazzy, almost romantic neo-noir soft synth motif as Zhora is shot, punctuated by the foley of breaking glass, and it removes us as participants from this chase. We are now just observers, and like Deckard, we are left to make our own judgement of Deckard’s actions and Zhora’s death. The music at this point seems incongruous with the action, but the softness and melody add to the visual dream-like quality and mirror the slow pacing of the shots as they really draw out her vulnerable and graceless physicality. It lends a sorrowful quality as well, as we often hear this motif throughout the film when replicants are exhibiting “human” behavior or when Deckard is having a moment of somber reflection.

These two sequences barely touch on all the ways that Ripley Scott and his team use elements of mise en scene, cinematography, and music to create this world in which

technology is god and humans are superior to artificial intelligence, even though the artificial intelligence seems to have a wider range of emotion and empathy – they seem more human than human, while many of the human characters seem cold and disinterested in one another. The dark, artificial lighting creates a somber atmosphere of consumerism and dystopia. The physical setting of futuristic-yet-familiar-looking buildings juxtaposed against symbols of industry and commodity reveals a dystopian future earth and a society founded upon industrial values; what is left of our once-sunbathed planet is now “lost in time, like tears in rain” (almost literally given the perpetual rainy weather). Staging of action reveals vulnerabilities about our main characters and also reveals considerable apathy on behalf of the society in which they live. The camera movement brings us into the action as a participant, so when we become the observer, the content has a more profound emotional impact and we are forced to ask the same philosophical questions Deckard asks. The colors are consistent across the film; we see bright neons, dark blue and green shadows, and high contrasts of cool and warm colors that create a very cold, shadowy, and unwelcoming artificial environment. The music establishes a tone reminiscent of noir dramas, often in which the main character has an existential crisis – very much the case here as Deckard grapples with his sense of humanity versus others. Most importantly, the framing and composition invite us to experience this conflict along with Deckard as it provides exposure and obscurity that enhance the narrative and provide cues in regard to who a character *really* is. Overall, Scott crafts a place and time in which it becomes possible to ask what makes us human, what it means to be human, and whether we have become less human in our commodification of life.